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The Gradual Regression of Violence Censorship in Romanticism

Beyond the work of Wordsworth, there have been a selection of poets who have kept romanticism alive by having elements of the style present in selections of their writing. One of these elements is the presence of violence, specifically a writer's aversion against censoring it. Although living through the same time period as Wordsworth, Shelley's poem *Ode to the West Wind* has traces of violence which stand out in a romantic work observing the might of nature. Rossetti's *Goblin Market* portrays elements of romanticism by not censoring its violence, allowing for it to be a central part of her poem. Wilfred Owen, the latest of these authors, also did not censor violence, using the horrors of war as an outlet of his emotion in the poem *Dulce et Decorum Est*. By adding moments of violence in their works, these authors assist in keeping romanticism alive, exhibiting how its elements are essential in creating a powerful piece of writing.

The poem *Ode to the West Wind* does not have the intense moments of violence which are found in poems by the aforementioned authors, but have small moments of violent language which are distinguishable from the praises of nature and passionate emotion which can be found within the romantic style of writing. One of these moments are early in the poem, with Shelley writing "The winged seeds, where they lie cold and low / Each like a corpse within its grave"(7-8). In these lines there is a seed, a part of nature responsible for new life, which is being juxtaposed with the image of a dead body lying within its final resting place. Rather than taking

the more common romantic approach of praising nature for its ability to sustain itself with the seed, Shelley uses a morbid, more violent representation of what the seed looks like in its dormant state, absent of any praise towards nature. Nature is still made to be the main focus of this poem, with each stanza of the poem making reference to it, but nature is not coddled by Shelley, who in this poem is not looking to solely preserve its grandeur.

Goblin Market by Christina Rossetti intensifies the amount of violence which can be found in a romantic piece of writing, although there is still some amount of restraint shown. In this poem, the assaults of Laura and Lizzie create the largest moments of drama and intensity, and although some deliberate acts of violence are masked by using various fruits as euphemisms for sexual organs, they can still be deciphered by Rossetti's descriptions. One of these euphemisms is found in the assault of Lizzie while visiting the goblins and their market.

Twitch'd her hair out by the roots,
Stamp'd upon her tender feet,
Held her hands and squeez'd their fruits
Against her mouth to make her eat.(404-407)

There is undeniable physical assault happening in this excerpt, with the verbs of 'twitch' and 'stamp' being associated with violence. Squeezing and eating fruit is not a violent action, but when the meaning of the fruit in this section is uncensored, it creates a moment more violent than the assault taking place on her hair and feet. There are a number of other violent actions described which take place during the previous and upcoming lines of the poem, yet some are still censored by using fruits as a euphemism, restraining some of the violence in the poem until it is given a closer read. Much like *Ode to the West Wind*, there is a clear effort made to introduce violence to a romantic piece of writing, yet there is still caution taken when writing about it.

The inclusion of violence in *Dulce et Decorum Est* by Wilfred Owen does not show the restraint practiced by Rossetti in *Goblin Market*, or minimal use seen in *Ode to the West Wind*. In this poem, Owen writes about the horrors of war, and how it should not be glorified by those hoping to enlist young men to fight for their country. Apart from the mortar fire and gas attacks the narrator describes seeing on the battlefield, the memory which haunts them the most is of their comrade succumbing to the mustard gas which coated the air in a thick green fog. "In all my dreams before my helpless sight, / He plunges at me, guttering, choking, drowning"(15-16). The narrator is mentally scarred by what he has seen on the battlefield, with the sight of this man spewing frothy blood from his mouth being stuck with him forever. Owen's writing does not try to mask the violence that a person can experience during the war, insisting instead on making it the focal point of this poem by using simple imagery to detail what the narrator experiences. In doing this, Owen is able to convey the message of war not being as glorious as the unexperienced may describe it, while also putting his own passion for this topic on display by using the shock factor created by not censoring any violence. This creates a direct link to the romantic style of writing, avoiding the masking of violence while still expressing his own passion.

Violence has the ability to exist in many different ways in poetry. Some violence can be related closer to the morbidity of life like in *Ode to the West Wind*, alluded to more thoroughly in works such as *Goblin Market*, or put on the forefront like in *Dulce et Decorum Est*. Regardless of the portrayal of violence in literature, there is still a direct connection to romanticism with its inclusion. Gradually lowering the censorship of violence in romantic writing over time shows how writers such as Shelley, Rossetti, and Owen were writing in hopes of keeping romanticism alive, allowing for the romantic style of writing to stay alive long past Wordsworth.

Works Cited

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